

University of Zagreb
Faculty of Croatian Studies

Philosophy of Politics:
Liberalism: historical development and
fundamental principles

Sandro Scansi

Liberalism: Historical Development and Fundamental Principles

- Historical origins and development
- Individual liberty and rights
- Limited government and rule of law
- Toleration and pluralism

What Is Liberalism?

- Liberalism is a family of political doctrines, not a single doctrine
- Individual liberty has a privileged position
- Political authority and coercion require justification
- Liberals disagree about equality, property and the proper scope of government

The Liberal Presumption

- Begin with the individual as presumptively free
- Political authority cannot simply be assumed
- Restrictions on liberty require justification
- Fundamental question:
 - Why may one person legitimately coerce another?

Historical Origins

- Reformation and religious conflict
- Rise of the sovereign state
- Constitutional struggles against absolutism
- Enlightenment and commercial society
- American and French Revolutions

Religious Conflict and Toleration

- Religious disagreement challenged the possibility of a unified Christian political order
- Toleration emerged as an alternative to enforced religious uniformity
- Political membership gradually became separable from religious conviction
- Central problem:
 - How can people with incompatible beliefs live together?

From Toleration to Pluralism

- Toleration gradually expands beyond religion
- Different moral beliefs and conceptions of the good become politically legitimate
- Political unity need not require cultural or moral uniformity
- Pluralism becomes a defining liberal problem

The Liberal Individual

- Individuals become bearers of rights
- Political institutions must be justified in relation to persons
- Collective purposes do not automatically override individual claims
- Liberalism rejects the idea that individuals exist simply for the state

John Locke

- *Second Treatise of Government* (1689)
- Natural freedom and equality
- Natural rights and property
- Consent and limited government
- Right of resistance

Locke: The State of Nature

- Human beings are naturally free and equal
- No individual possesses natural political authority over another
- Individuals possess rights before government exists
- Political authority must therefore be explained and justified

Locke: Natural Rights

- Life
- Liberty
- Property
- Rights do not simply originate from government
- Government exists in significant part to protect pre-existing rights

Locke and Property

- Individuals have a claim over their own persons and labor
- Labor plays a central role in Locke's account of appropriation
- Property exists prior to political government
- Protection of property becomes a central purpose of political society

Why Create Government?

- Rights in the state of nature remain insecure
- Individuals are partial judges in their own disputes
- Government provides established law, impartial judgment and enforcement
- Government should make rights more secure, not replace them

Consent and Legitimacy

- Natural equality excludes automatic political authority
- Legitimate political society therefore requires consent
- Government exercises delegated rather than unlimited authority
- The governed are the source of legitimate political power

Limited Government

- Government is created for particular purposes
- Its powers are limited by those purposes
- Political power exists for the governed
- Arbitrary power violates the logic of legitimate government

The Right of Resistance

- Government exercises political power as a trust
- Systematic violation of rights constitutes a breach of that trust
- Society and government are conceptually distinct
- Resistance can therefore become legitimate

The Liberal Constitutional State

- Government through general laws
- Protection of individual rights
- Representative and accountable institutions
- Limits on executive power
- Government must be both *effective and constrained*

Rule of Law

- Law rather than arbitrary personal command
- Public, relatively stable and generally applicable rules
- Rulers themselves are subject to legal constraints
- Freedom requires protection against arbitrary power

Liberalism and Revolution

- American Revolution, 1776
- French Revolution, 1789
- Rights become constitutional claims
- Citizens increasingly replace subjects as the normative political model

Liberalism and Democracy

- Liberalism asks: *What may government legitimately do?*
- Democracy asks: *Who should exercise political power?*
- Majority rule does not automatically protect individual liberty
- Liberal democracy combines popular government with constitutional limitations

The Problem of Majority Power

- Democratic power remains political power
- Majorities can threaten minorities
- Popular opinion can threaten individual freedom
- The liberal problem of limited power therefore survives democratization

John Stuart Mill

- *On Liberty* (1859)
- Individual liberty
- Freedom of expression
- Individuality
- Limits of social and political coercion

Tyranny of the Majority

- Domination can come from society as well as government
- Public opinion can enforce conformity
- Social pressure can restrict individuality
- Individuals therefore require protection against both state and society

The Harm Principle

- Individual liberty should enjoy a protected sphere
- Preventing harm to others can justify coercion
- A person's own good is normally insufficient justification for coercion
- The principle establishes a strong presumption against paternalism

Freedom of Thought and Discussion

- A suppressed opinion might be true
- Competing positions may each contain part of the truth
- Unchallenged truths can become “dead dogma”
- Free discussion therefore has both moral and epistemic value

Mill and Individuality

- Liberty permits experimentation in ways of living
- Individuality is part of human development
- Diversity can generate social learning
- Conformity can impoverish both individuals and society

Two Concepts of Liberty

- **Negative liberty:** freedom from interference
- **Positive liberty:** self-direction or self-mastery
- Both can plausibly be described as forms of freedom
- Their relationship becomes a major internal liberal debate

The Transformation of Liberalism

- Industrialization creates new forms of dependence and inequality
- Is legal freedom sufficient without meaningful opportunities?
- Can private economic power also restrict freedom?
- Some liberals therefore defend a larger role for government

Two Liberal Tendencies

- **Classical liberalism:** limited government, markets, property, contractual freedom
- **Social liberalism:** effective freedom may require education and social provision
- Both appeal to liberty
- They disagree about what liberty requires from the state

Liberalism and Equality

- Equality before the law is foundational
- Equality of opportunity becomes increasingly important
- Liberals disagree about economic and social equality
- Central question: *When does inequality become incompatible with liberty?*

Liberalism and Property

- Property can protect personal independence
- Private ownership decentralizes economic decision-making
- Liberals disagree about taxation, redistribution and regulation
- Property is therefore both a liberal principle and an internal liberal controversy

Friedrich A. Hayek

- *The Road to Serfdom* (1944)
- Economic planning and political freedom
- Rule of law
- Decentralized knowledge
- Dangers of concentrated political-economic power

Hayek: Planning and Freedom

- Comprehensive planning requires collective priorities
- Collective priorities require authoritative decisions among competing ends
- Economic control can therefore concentrate political power
- Hayek contrasts general rules with detailed direction of social outcomes

Hayek and Knowledge

- Knowledge is dispersed throughout society
- Individuals possess local information unavailable to central authorities
- Markets can coordinate decentralized knowledge
- Fundamental question: *Who knows enough to organize society?*

Isaiah Berlin

- *Two Concepts of Liberty* (1958)
- **Negative liberty:** How far am I free from interference?
- **Positive liberty:** Who governs or controls me?
- Different understandings of liberty can generate different political projects

Berlin and Value Pluralism

- Important human values can conflict
- Liberty, equality, justice and security cannot always be perfectly reconciled
- Political choices can involve genuine losses
- Liberal pluralism rejects the assumption of one final harmonious political order

Libertarianism

- Radical presumption against coercion
- Strong individual and property rights
- Voluntary exchange and association
- Sharp skepticism toward redistribution and expansive government

Robert Nozick

- *Anarchy, State, and Utopia* (1974)
- Individual rights constrain collective purposes
- Individuals cannot simply be sacrificed for aggregate welfare
- Nozick defends a minimal state

Nozick and Distributive Justice

- Justice concerns how holdings were acquired and transferred
- Voluntary transactions continually change distributions
- A preferred distributive pattern may require repeated state interference
- Central conflict: *property rights vs. redistributive equality*

Fundamental Principles of Liberalism

- Individual moral importance and liberty
- Rights and equality before the law
- Consent, constitutionalism and rule of law
- Toleration and pluralism
- Political coercion requires justification

The Fundamental Liberal Tensions

- Liberty vs. equality
- Property vs. redistribution
- Majority rule vs. minority rights
- Negative vs. positive liberty
- State power vs. private power
- Fundamental question:
How much coercion can a society committed to freedom legitimately exercise?